PRE-PURCHASE INSPECTION CHECKLIST

Jeep Wagoneer & Cherokee (SJ)

1963–1983 · SJ · Wagoneer · Cherokee · Cherokee Chief

BOXYTRUCKS

CHECK BEFORE YOU BUY

- [ ] **Rust first**
  It's the same body as the Grand Wagoneer, and Hagerty's buyer's guide for that truck calls rust the biggest concern: floor pans under the front carpet, the area where the fuel tank meets the body, the frame and underbody, and the front fenders. Original front fenders are no longer made. Floor, rocker and lower-quarter repair panels are still sold.

- [ ] **Find out which 4WD system it has**
  This matters for parts, fluids and how it drives. A one-lever floor shifter on a 1974–79 automatic is the Borg-Warner Quadra-Trac; a manual from those years has a Dana 20. The 1980–82 'Quadra-Trac' is really an NP219, and 1980–83 trucks may have a part-time NP208 or, from mid-1982, Selec-Trac with a dash switch.

- [ ] **Listen in tight turns**
  The factory manual describes Quadra-Trac 'stick-slip': a low grunting or rasping noise when turning slowly or parking. It's usually the wrong fluid, mismatched tires or uneven pressures. A much louder noise when driving straight points to a stretched chain. Team Grand Wagoneer's chain kit is aimed at trucks with more than about 120,000 miles or skipped fluid changes.

- [ ] **Check the Chief is a Chief**
  The real Chief from 1976 has wider axles and flared fenders and was only built as a two-door. On 1981–83 VINs, characters 6–7 read 16 or 17 for a two-door Cherokee and 18 for a four-door; 15 is a Wagoneer. Golden Eagles are Chiefs with a big hood decal, gold-painted steel wheels and denim seats, so look for more than a sticker.

- [ ] **Drive it cold and hot**
  Hagerty's Grand Wagoneer specialist blames the Motorcraft carburetor for about 40% of owner headaches. Expect stumbling, hard hot starts and ignition faults on an untouched truck. NHTSA recalled 1975–76 trucks for ignition wiring connectors that could not carry enough current (78V-065).

- [ ] **Work the tailgate window**
  The power rear glass has to come down before the tailgate opens. Recall 87V-178 covers 1970–83 Wagoneers and Cherokees whose key-operated window kept closing if the spring-loaded key failed to return. Test the dash switch, the key switch and the glass travel.

- [ ] **Look at the brakes**
  Early Cherokees had four-wheel drums as standard, with front discs optional; Wagoneers got front discs as standard from 1974. Check what's fitted and how old the steel lines are. Pre-bent stainless kits exist for 1977-on trucks.

- [ ] **Budget for scarce parts**
  Specialists such as Team Grand Wagoneer and BJ's Off Road stock most mechanical and body parts. But on the later Grand Wagoneer, Hagerty's specialist estimates about 20% of restoration parts still come from salvage yards. Two-door-specific trim and glass are harder to find than Wagoneer parts.

RECALLS TO ASK ABOUT

- ☐ **Key-operated tailgate window keeps closing**
  1970–1983 · NHTSA 87V-178
- ☐ **Ignition wiring connectors**
  1975–1976 · NHTSA 78V-065
- ☐ **Rear wheel bearings**
  1979–1980 · NHTSA 80V-023
- ☐ **Throttle linkage return spring**
  1978 (Cherokee) · NHTSA 78V-003
- ☐ **Transmission throttle-rod spring**
  1981 · NHTSA 81V-015
- ☐ **Manual transmission lubricant**
  1982 · NHTSA 82V-125

IS IT THE REAL THING?

- ☐ **SJ vs XJ**
  The SJ is body-on-frame on a 108.7 in wheelbase with six-lug wheels (from 1974). The 1984-on Cherokee and the 1984–90 Wagoneer Limited are compact unibody XJs.
- ☐ **Real wide-track Chief**
  Chiefs from 1976 have wider axles and larger fender flares, and were never built as four-doors. Golden Eagles add denim seats, gold-painted steel wheels and a big gold hood eagle.
- ☐ **VIN, 1981–83**
  Character 4 is the engine (C = 258 six, N = 360 V8); 5 is the transmission and transfer case; 6–7 are the body (15 = Wagoneer, 16/17 = two-door Cherokee, 18 = four-door Cherokee); 10 is the year (B = 1981, C = 1982, D = 1983); 11 is the plant (T = Toledo, B = Brampton). The VIN is also stamped on a tag on the upper-left firewall.
- ☐ **Early VINs**
  Pre-1981 VINs use an older, shorter format. Wikipedia lists the first-year 1974 Cherokees as Model 16 (base) and Model 17 (S).
- ☐ **Transfer case**
  1974–79 automatics with a single floor lever have the Borg-Warner Quadra-Trac; 1974–79 manuals have a Dana 20. From 1980 look for a tag reading NP208, NP219 or NP229; Selec-Trac trucks have a 2WD/4WD switch.

NOTES

From the full guide at https://boxytrucks.com/models/jeep/sj-wagoneer/, with sources. Recalls follow the VIN: check at nhtsa.gov/recalls. General information only, not a professional inspection; see boxytrucks.com/about/disclaimer/. © BoxyTrucks